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WHEN I WAS THIRTEEN OR FOURTEEN, my father took the family for a Sunday drive through the green countryside bordering Dixon. As usual, my parents sat in the front seat and my brother and I sat in the back.

Nelle had left her eyeglasses in the back seat, and as we approached the gently rolling prairie outside town, I picked up her glasses and put them on.

The next instant, I let out a yelp that almost caused Jack to run off the road. Nobody knew what I was yelling about, but I'd discovered a world I didn't know existed before.

Until then, a tree beside the road looked like a green blob and a billboard was a fuzzy haze. Suddenly I was able to see branches on trees and *leaves* on the branches. There were words as well as pictures on billboards. "Look!" I shouted, pointing to a herd of grazing dairy cows I hadn't seen before.

I was astounded.

By picking up my mother's glasses, I had discovered that I was extremely nearsighted. A new world suddenly opened up to me. The reason I'd been such a lousy baseball player was that I couldn't see a pitch until it was about three feet from me. Now I knew why I'd always been the last kid chosen for the baseball team. And I also knew why I'd always jockeyed to get a desk in the front row at school. I hadn't realized before that the other kids could see the blackboard from the back of the room.

The next day, my eyes were tested by a doctor and I found out how blind I really was and was fitted with my own pair of glasses—thick, black-rimmed monstrosities I despised that soon had my friends calling me "Four Eyes."